

States **BIHAR**

Faith of CHOICE

Sikhism is the new destination for the residents of a Dalit village seeking to break caste barriers

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

It's a nondescript temple at Halhalia village in Bihar's Araria district. It doesn't have an idol; a mound of earth in one corner of the roofless one-room shrine represents Din Bhadri Devi, the local deity. Its walls are bare, but for priest Amlanand Rishidev, there is a more pressing problem than the upkeep of the temple: there is no one to inherit his priesthood. Halhalia village is home to over 100 families of which 28 have converted to Sikhism. So have about a hundred families in several adjoining villages of the district, including Parwanpur, Godbelsara, Bakhri and Maudhabalia. Amlanand, however, isn't bitter about the "gradual obliteration of faith". His only son Nirdosh Singh and his family have also converted to Sikhism. The men sport straggly beards, wear *saafas* and have *kirpans* slung across their shoulders. The women still wear saris and on special occasions they slip into the traditional *salwar-kurta*. Pidgin Punjabi can be heard everywhere, even though the womenfolk have never visited Punjab.

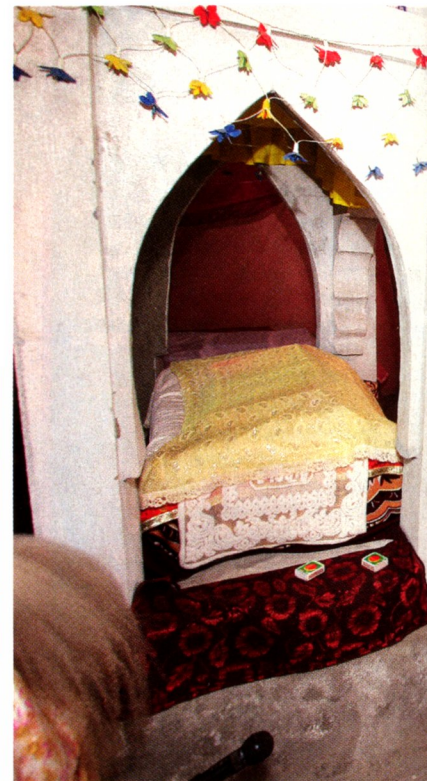
The first to convert was Gyani Narendra Singh Rishidev, who visited Punjab in 1985 to earn a living and converted to Sikhism a few years later. "We have a natural leaning for this religion. After all, Guru Gobind Singh was born in Patna," he says. Upon returning to his village, the 38-year-old inspired many of his folk to convert. The lone gurdwara here stands on Narendra's inherited land.



“Sikhism is not against anyone. It is good to see people gravitating towards the teachings of the gurus.”

SINGH SAHIB GYANI EKBAAL SINGH,
Jathedar of Takht Sri Harimandirji, Patna Sahib

The Rishidevs in Araria belong to the Mushahar caste, the poorest Dalit community known as untouchable rat-eaters. By changing their religion, Dalits believe they get a distinct identity. Narendra's younger brother Sanjay is more vocal about the "inequality" practised in Hindu society. "Upper caste folks still don't share their meals with us. Even today, many of them abhor us. Our conversion to Sikhism is a cry for human dignity. It denounces discrimination and prejudice on the basis of caste, class and status," he says. These conversions also make economic sense. Many of these neo-con-



verts have now found regular work at gurdwaras in Punjab. "But this is not why we have embraced Sikhism. In fact, like other devout Sikhs, we also do *kar sewa* and donate one month of service," insists Narendra.

Sanjay's criticism is not entirely off the mark. These conversions are not aimed at puncturing the reform balloon; they put a question mark on Dalit reforms instead. For instance, though the Bihar State Board of Religious Trusts led by its administrator Acharya Kishore Kunal has made significant efforts by introducing a dozen "untouchables" into priesthood, it is unlikely to make real changes on the ground. Even the state Government's highly touted "slew of welfare measures for the Mahadalits" is yet to percolate beyond symbolic fault-lines. Kunal, a former IPS officer, believes that these conversions suggest "freedom of practising a religion". "Hinduism is all inclusive. We espouse *sangat-pangat*